

WordNet Structure: Words, Senses, Synsets, and Relations

(Course slides)

January 12, 2026

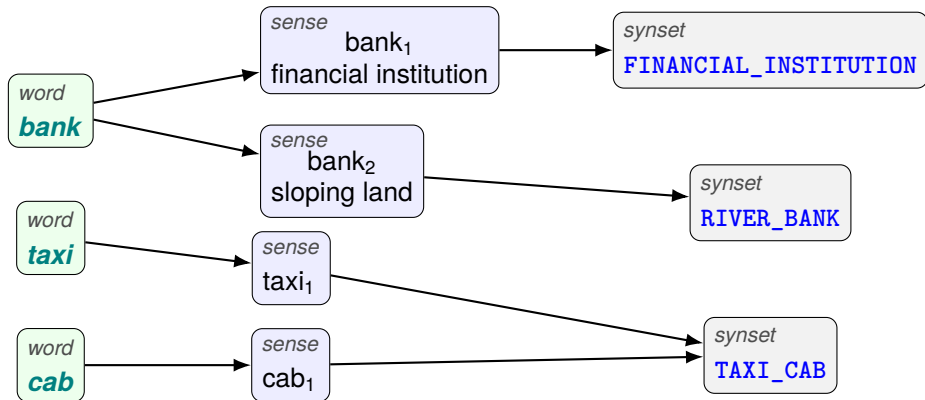


Big idea: a lexicon organized by concepts

- A **word form** can express **multiple meanings** (polysemy).
- A **meaning** can be expressed by **multiple word forms** (synonymy).
- WordNets model meaning with:
 - ▶ **Words** (forms)
 - ▶ **Senses** (a word-in-a-particular-meaning)
 - ▶ **Synsets** (concepts; sets of near-synonymous senses)
 - ▶ **Relations** between synsets/senses



Words → Senses → Synsets



Key: **senses** link **words** to **synsets** (concepts).

What **Words** have

- **Canonical Form (Lemma):** the written form(s) used in the lexicon
- **Part of speech**
- **Variant forms**
 - ▶ spelling variants (*colour/color*), scripts (犬 / いぬ), casing/diacritics policy, irregular forms (*child/children* [pl]),
- **Form metadata** (when present in a resource)
 - ▶ pronunciations, transliterations, orthographic variants type (US/UK)
 - ▶ morphological class (plural, past), if the resource encodes them at word-level
- **Derivations:** links to words related by derivation
- **Sense(s):**
 - ▶ one Word can have multiple Senses (polysemy)
 - ▶ all those senses share the same *string forms* but differ in meaning



Form metadata example

```
<LexicalEntry id="ex-gato-n">
  <Lemma writtenForm="gato" partOfSpeech="n">
    <Tag category="gender">masculine</Tag>
  </Lemma>
  <Form writtenForm="gatos">
    <Tag category="number">plural</Tag>
  </Form>
</LexicalEntry>
```

- Grammatical properties such as gender, number, case, and tense can be represented with the `<Tag>` element.
- The `<Tag>` element has a `category` attribute which indicates the type of grammatical property, and the value is the text of the tag
- A universal tagging scheme is not prescribed — wordnet project owners are free to choose a scheme

What **Senses** have

- A **sense** is the pairing: **Word** × **Synset**
- Sense-level properties often include:
 - ▶ **Sense IDs / keys** (resource-specific identifiers)
 - ▶ **Frequency / counts** (e.g., corpus-based tagging counts)
 - ▶ **Derivations** (constrained by meaning)
 - ▶ **Usage examples** (example sentences tied to this meaning)
 - ▶ **Syntactic/verb frames** (common in some WordNet-style resources)
 - ▶ **Sense-level relations** such as antonymy
- Why sense-level? Because **frequency and examples depend on the meaning**, not just the string or the concept.

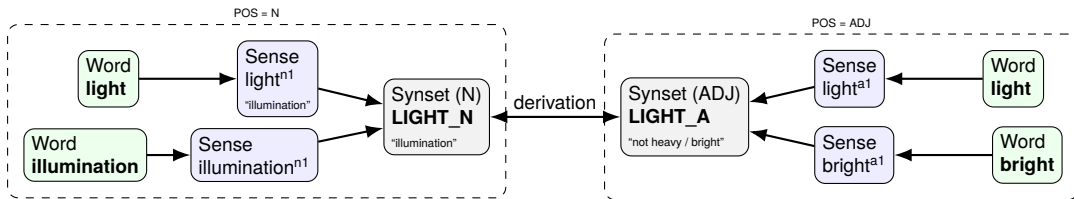


What **Synsets** have

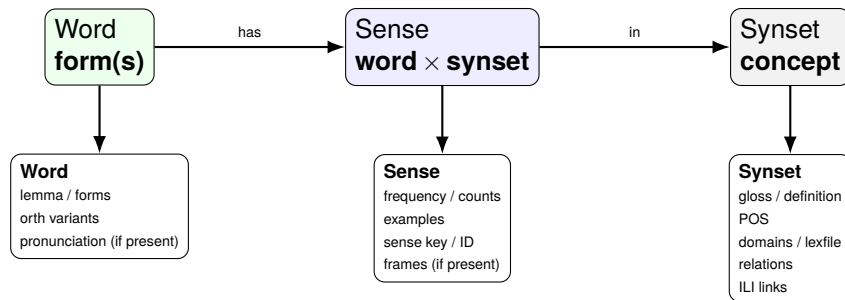
- A **synset** represents a **concept** (language-internal, but linkable).
- Typical synset-level properties:
 - ▶ **Definition / gloss** (concept description)
 - ▶ **Usage examples** (example sentences)
 - ▶ **Part of speech** (noun/verb/adj/adv in many resources)
 - ▶ **Semantic fields / domains** (e.g., *lexicographer files*)
 - ▶ **Concept relations**: hypernym, meronym, cause, etc.
 - ▶ **ILI links** (interlingual index), when available
- Why synset-level? Because these describe the **concept itself**, independent of which word expresses it.

POS-specific variants: concepts live in POS-specific synsets

- A synset is typically **POS-specific** (noun synset vs adjective synset, etc.).
- The “same general idea” across POS is modeled via **relations between synsets**, not by mixing POS inside one synset.

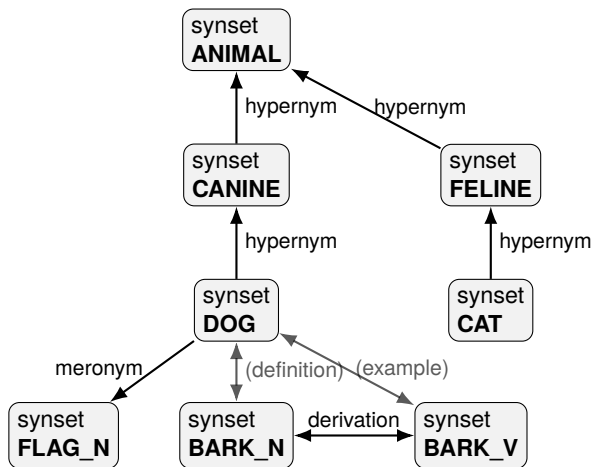


Cheat sheet: where does each kind of information live?



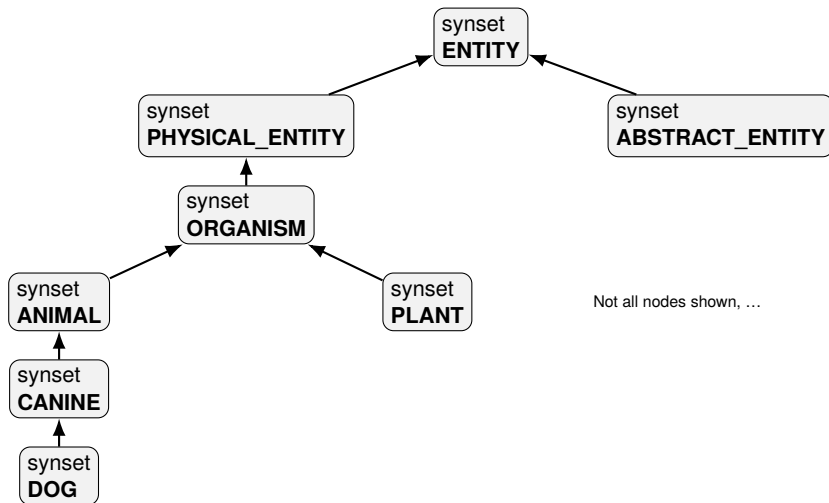
Rule of thumb: *form* → Word; *usage of a meaning* → Sense; *concept + relations* → Synset.

Relations: building a graph over concepts



WordNets are **graphs**: taxonomy-like relations (e.g. hypernymy) plus many non-taxonomic links (meronymy, cause, related, used in example/definition etc.).

The taxonomy: a (mostly) rooted hierarchy for nouns



Multiple inheritance is possible, loops are not, for OEWN 2025, verbs are also rooted.

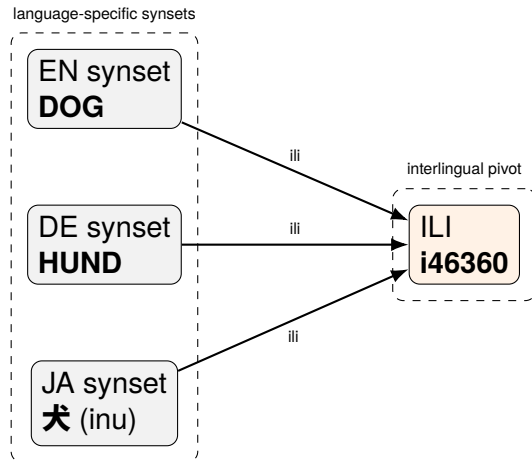
Lexicons, IDs, and versions (in `wn`)

- A **WordNet resource** is packaged as a **lexicon** (often: 1 lexicon per resource).
- `wn` supports multiple lexicons (and multiple versions) in one database.
- Lexicon specifiers (examples):
 - ▶ `ewn:2020` = a specific lexicon & version
 - ▶ `ewn:*` = all versions of `ewn`
 - ▶ `*` = all lexicons

Most of the time it is better to use a single lexicon (e.g. `ewn=wn.Wordnet('oewn:2024')`)



Interlingual Index (ILI): linking concepts across languages



ILI enables “same concept, different languages” queries when lexicons provide ILI links



Summary: what to remember

- 1 **Synset** $\approx$ **concept node**; a set of synonyms, that makes up a concept. Can be non-lexicalized!
- 2 **Relations** turn synsets and senses into a richly typed graph.
- 3 **Taxonomy** (hypernymy) gives a hierarchy (esp. nouns).
- 4 **Lexicons** + versions allow reproducibility.
- 5 **ILI** enables cross-lingual alignment when available.
- 6 **Properties live at different layers**: form (Word), usage (Sense), concept (Synset).

Different Wordnet Projects contain different information, OMW tries to harmonize when possible